

Pride for All: Closing the Inclusion Gap for Disability and Rural Communities

TO:

- Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD), Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
- National Council for Transgender Persons (NCTP), Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
- Ministry of Information & Broadcasting (I&B)

CC:

- Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA)
- Ministry of Law and Justice
- Chief Commissioners for Persons with Disabilities (State-level)

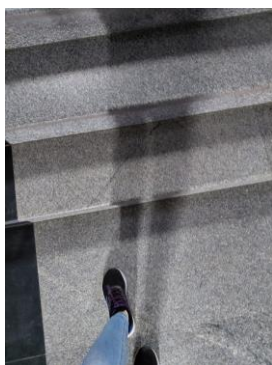
1. Orientation

Most of us know Pride Parades as a celebration of different gender and sexual identities. But it did not start as a celebration but as a riot. It started with the 1969 Stonewall Uprising, led by the forgotten people in the community. Pride has always had three goals, visibility (to take up space in the public and say "we are here"), community (to get support from others) and advocacy (to push for fair treatment and stop unfair treatment).

As Pride has gotten bigger it has started to follow a model that's for cities for middle-class people and, for people who are not disabled. This creates a gap where the people who need support and recognition the most are left behind. Fixing this gap means changing from saying "you are welcome to come" to building support and fighting for change so that everyone can take part.

2. Basis for This Brief

This brief draws on primary fieldwork alongside two interviews cited throughout with disabled individuals about their experience of Pride, and a site visit along the Delhi Pride route, that is, Barakhamba Road to Tolstoy Road to Jantar Mantar. This was done to document the accessibility barriers firsthand.



No ramps or tactile cues at kerbs along the route.



Bollards narrow the path to less than a wheelchair's width.



Uneven paving and street furniture block a clear line of travel.

We found several issues with accessibility from walkability, to informational and financial barriers, to linguistic and geographic hurdles. However, the onus of responsibility for the lack of disability and rural inclusion cannot be placed on any one entity alone.

3. Understanding the Layers of Exclusion

In this brief that barriers to inclusion are split into two layers, for both disability and rural exclusion. Intrinsic barriers sit within Pride's own design and are addressable by organisers. Extrinsic barriers cover the public infrastructure, government policy, and the social fabric and require government action.

Part A: The Case for Disability Inclusion

This section applies the Social Model of Disability which locates “disability” in an inaccessible environment, not in an individual's body or mind. This model is a recognised standard behind India's Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016.

3.1 The Problems

Intrinsic Barriers (Pride's own design)	Extrinsic Barriers (state & society)
• Lack of shaded rest stops along parade routes • Post-Pride parties held in inaccessible venues (stairs, no lifts) • Overwhelming sensory environment (drums, whistles, crowd density) • Information disseminated only on visually-focused platforms • Speeches and performances delivered without ISL interpretation	• Last mile inaccessibility, broken pavements, no curb cuts • Near-total absence of accessible public toilets • Crowd density, heat, and humidity of urban areas • Financial and logistical barriers to reach urban Pride events • Double closet: life-threatening risk of family rejection and loss of care

3.2 Solutions

Part I: What Pride Committees Can Do

- **Pitching rest stops.** Parade routes currently have no shaded rest points, which makes the physical distance of a march a barrier on its own for anyone with limited stamina, chronic illness, or mobility aids. It is a low-cost, volunteer-run fix that doesn't require any external approval.
- **Sensory advisories and aids.** The loud, dense sensory environment of Pride (drums, whistles, crowds) can trigger sensory overload for autistic, anxious, or PTSD-affected attendees. Using a simple advance warning and cheap earmuffs let people choose to prepare rather than being excluded by surprise.
- **Audio, visual, and audio-visual reach.** Outreach currently runs almost entirely through Instagram, which silently excludes non-fluent English speakers, low-vision/blind community members, and anyone without heavy social media use, adding radio and other channels widens who even finds out Pride is happening.
- **Inclusive post-Pride events.** The real community-building happens at post-Pride gatherings, but these are routinely held in walk-up venues with no lifts, locking out exactly the people the parade itself worked to include. Moving them to ground-level public parks removes that barrier at no cost.

Part II: Required Policy Action

Pillar 1: Enforcement of Universal Physical Accessibility

- **Mandate accessibility audits as a precondition for public event permits.** DEPwD, with MoHUA, should direct Municipal Corporations to withhold permits for large public gatherings until the route, assembly points, and public toilets pass an accessibility audit. RPwD Act, 2016 and the Harmonised Guidelines for Universal Accessibility (precedent: Title II of the US Americans with Disabilities Act, which places this burden on the permitting authority).
- **Make public transport funding conditional on accessibility compliance.** Central funding for state-level metro, bus, and railway modernisation should be conditional on audited compliance with the Harmonised Guidelines. Field interviews confirm an accessible metro is the single most effective tool for inclusion.

Pillar 2: Mandating Intersectional and Informational Access

- **Legally recognise Indian Sign Language (ISL).** MoSJE should legislate official-language status for ISL requiring state-funded ISL interpretation at government-sanctioned public events.
- **Establish Media Anonymity Zones.** The Ministry of I&B, with state police, should set guidelines for media conduct at public protests, including designated media zones and finable offences for filming individuals outside them without consent.

Pillar 3: Justice, Safety, and Intersectional Support Services

- **Mandate intersectional training for police and judiciary.** NCTP and DEPwD should jointly fund mandatory sensitisation training on compounded gender-based, queer-phobic, and ableist violence.
- **Mandate accessibility for state-funded crisis shelters.** MoSJE should expand the Swadhar Greh and Garima Greh schemes to serve all LGBTQIA+ individuals fleeing family violence, including disabled persons, conditional on an RPwD-compliant accessibility audit, the most direct answer to the double closet.

Part B: The Case for Rural Inclusion

The default urban model of pride excludes the majority of India's queer population, those in Tier-2 cities, Tier-3 towns, and rural villages, for whom attending a metro-city pride is a question not of preference but of possibility.

3.3 The Problems

Intrinsic Barriers (Pride's own design)	Extrinsic Barriers (state & society)
- Overwhelmingly English-centric lexicon of Pride (“LGBTQ”, “queer”, “non-binary”) - Media presence taking pictures and videos without consent; threat of outing	- Cost of multi-day travel and board to reach a metro-city Pride - Underfunded grassroots LGBTQIA+ organisations outside metros - Poor public transport access in small towns - Digital divide, limited or expensive internet connectivity - Derogatory or pathologising terms in local-language lexicons - Lack of anonymity in small towns and villages - Double closet; risk of family violence, forced marriage, or disownment if outed

3.4 Solutions

Part I: What Pride Committees Can Do

Pride already does a great deal right, community-building events (fundraisers, mixers) and a helpful, inclusive culture that encourages newcomers to ask for help. The gap, however, is the reach.

- **The masked parade.** Formally dedicate one side of the parade to masked or costumed attendees for anonymous participation, with advisories encouraging face coverings, already an accepted, easy way to blend in.
- **Reach in local areas, languages, and mediums.** Fund awareness campaigns that democratise pride’s language, translate materials into regional languages, and support smaller local events rather than requiring travel to metros.

Part II: Required Policy Action

Public Service Broadcasting Initiative

The core problem for rural citizens is not a lack of rights but a total failure of information dissemination. The Ministry of I&B, with the Ministry of Law and Justice and MoSJE, should mandate a public-service campaign carrying three pieces of information, aired in all 22 scheduled languages via Doordarshan and All India Radio:

- A statement that same-sex relationships between consenting adults are not illegal, per the Navtej Singh Johar judgment.
- A statement of transgender persons' legal rights, per the NALSA judgment and the Transgender Persons Act, 2019.
- Contact information for state-run support services, the Swadhar Greh and Garima Greh shelter schemes and the national Transgender helpline (1-800-11-0017).

This design bypasses all three key rural barriers: it needs no internet, since DD/AIR reach areas the digital divide does not; it mandates regional languages, removing the english colonisation of queerness that privileges the urban, English-educated; and it substitutes an official external source of information for local stigma and surveillance.

Feasibility

- **Fiscally neutral.** The broadcasting initiative uses the existing DD/AIR network at negligible marginal cost. The disability pillars ask for enforcement of existing law and conditions on existing funding streams, not new appropriations.
- **Politically and legally palatable.** None of these recommendations ask government to fund a Pride parade. They ask it to enforce settled law (RPwD Act, Navtej Singh Johar, NALSA) and run the kind of legal-literacy campaign it already runs for Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, farmers' rights, and COVID-19 awareness.

Conclusion

The first Pride wasn't a parade, it was a riot for the right to exist with dignity. The inclusion gap that keeps disabled and rural citizens from ever reaching a Pride event is not a failure of malice, it is a failure of enforcement and imagination, and one squarely within the state's existing legal and infrastructural mandate to fix. These recommendations ask for nothing beyond the enforcement of rights India has already guaranteed its citizens.